

NEW EQUATIONS Modi in conversation with Russian president Vladimir Putin and his Chinese counterpart Xi Jinping at the SCO Summit, Sept. 1, 2025

AFP

the two leaders enjoy warm ties, the Indo-US relationship is governed by hard campaign commitments, especially on issues such as immigration, trade and inflation." The first shock came on April 2, when Trump announced tariffs against several countries, including India, even as Indian trade negotiators began engaging with their US counterparts. To New Delhi's disappointment, he pegged tariffs at a high 25 per cent for Indian exporters, effective August 1.

US Ties Go Downhill

Trade, though, would not be the only friction point. Immigration, both illegal and legal, were at the heart of Trump's election campaign, and India began to bear the brunt. Trump initiated the process of deporting illegal immigrants, and the estimated 400,000 Indians living illegally in the US did not escape the clutches of America's Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) agency. When photographs of the first batch of illegal Indians being deported on chartered aircraft appeared, their legs chained and wearing handcuffs, it created an uproar in Indian political circles. That led to ICE officials assuring their Indian counterparts that women and children will not be leg-chained, but the deportation has proceeded quietly and steadily. An estimated 3,000 people have been sent back since Trump's return, the highest in recent years. But more was in store, as Trump tightened the rules for H1B visas, impacting nearly 750,000 Indians working in the US and triggering another trail of returnees.

> **"Prime Minister Modi knows his third term is all about crafting a legacy and that history will judge him not just by what he builds but also by what he dismantles"**
>
> **— Nripendra Misra**
> *Former Principal Secretary to the PM*

Yet the main rupture between Trump and Modi would occur because of unexpected circumstances. After the terror attack in Pahalgam on April 22, PM Modi ordered Indian armed forces to launch aerial strikes on nine sites, mostly in the heart of Pakistan, on May 7. Operation Sindoor, as the mission was called, triggered the sixth Indo-Pak war that would last four days before the two sides agreed to a ceasefire on May 10. While India maintained that it was Pakistan that begged for a ceasefire, embarrassingly for Modi, a Trump post on Truth Social claimed he had brokered the peace.

It is a claim Trump has made an estimated 60 times since then, undermining India's carefully-constructed narrative and exposing New Delhi's limits in shaping global percep-